

Behavior Management for the Neurodiversity-Affirming SLP

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Disclosures

- Financial:
 - I have no financial disclosures related to this presentation. I receive a salary from DeSales University.
- Non-financial:
 - I have no non-financial disclosures related to this presentation.

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What's the deal with Applied Behavior Analysis (ABA)?

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What is ABA?

- Not a specific intervention or strategy, but the **broad discipline** of using behavioral principles to provide treatment
- Involves the study and modification of **observable actions** (i.e., behaviors) and **environmental contingencies**



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ABA controversy (part 1)

1. ABA is viewed unfavorably by many autistic people
 - (e.g., Anderson, 2022: <https://doi.org/10.1177/13623613221118216>)
 - Autistic adults report trauma from ABA
 - Do not believe they should be made to behave like their peers
 - Negative long-term consequences may outweigh benefits
 - Perceived as unethical



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ABA controversy (part 2)

2. There are frequent clashes between SLP and ABA, on a broad scale but also an individual level (e.g., Volkert, 2020: <https://leader.pubs.asha.org/doi/10.1044/leader.FTR2.25102020.52>)
 - Different understanding of child development, especially language: Skinnerian vs. cognitive/psycholinguistic approaches
 - Concerns about scope of practice, encroachment, reimbursement
 - Concerns about children's agency and ethics
 - Conflicting treatment goals, interventions, and strategies

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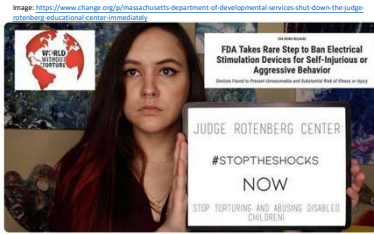
Primary objections

1. The methods of ABA

- Electroshock and other aversive stimuli
- Withholding, withdrawal, and deprivation
- Violations of bodily autonomy

2. The objectives of ABA

- Neuroconformity
- Prioritizing neurotypical comfort
- Forced compliance and masking



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Premises:

1. Behavioral approaches change *behaviors*, but many “challenging behaviors” are the product of autistic/neurodivergent characteristics
2. The methods and objectives of ABA are often dubious at best, and abusive at worst
3. Behaviors can be harmless or harmful
4. A “neurodiversity-affirming” approach to behavior management involves acceptance of harmless autistic behaviors, and addressing underlying causes of harmful behaviors
5. Behavioral principles may be useful for addressing underlying causes, even if the methods and objectives of ABA are shunned

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Two essential behavioral principles

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#1: Function-based thinking

And the corresponding
"Functional Behavior Assessments"

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Interpreting behaviors

Question: Is it true that “all behavior is communication?”

- Answer:** NO!
 - Communication involves the intentional exchange of information between people
 - Behaviors: Not always intentional/volitional
 - Behaviors: Not always exchanges between people

Question: Is it true that all behaviors have a function?

- Answer:** NO!
 - Nonvolitional behaviors

Question: Is it true that we can interpret certain wants and needs from a person’s behavior?

- Answer:** YES!

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Principle 1: 
“F-B-A...
It’s easy as A-B-C”

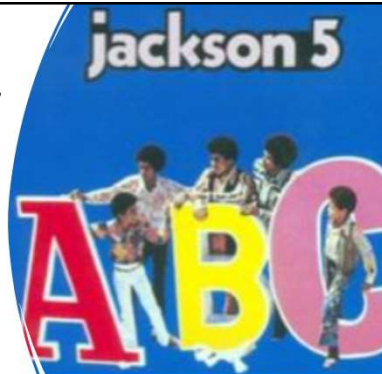
Antecedent

↓

Behavior

↓

Consequence



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Functional behavior assessment

- [Most] behaviors have functions
 - Request/obtain
 - Escape/avoid
 - Sensory/stimulation
- Select a “target behavior,” and systematically collect data about the antecedents and consequences

Image: <https://www.sampleforms.com/functional-behavior-assessment-form.html>

Functional Behavior Assessment Observation Form

Student: _____ Date: _____

Class/Teacher: _____ Observer: _____

Intervention Activity: _____ Other Relevant Information: _____

Time	Antecedent	Behavior	Consequence

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Basic example

Antecedent	Behavior	Consequence
Teacher asked students to turn in homework, but student had not completed homework	Student is disruptive in classroom setting. Frequently makes loud jokes mocking the lesson, the teacher, or classmates.	Teacher sends student to Assistant Principal's office. They have a talk, the student agrees to apologize, and returns to class with a lollipop.

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Functional analysis

- Measure the behavior:
 - Frequency
 - Duration
 - Intensity
- What is the effect of the consequence?
 - Increase behavior
 - Decrease behavior
- Hypothesize the function of the behavior
 - Request/obtain?
 - Escape/avoid?
 - Sensory/stimulation?

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#2:
Consequences
=/
punishments

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Principle 2

- Consider different types of consequences, and the effects of each!
- Terminology:
 - Positive = Adding or providing something
 - Negative = Removing something
 - Reward = Something that makes behavior **more likely** to repeat
 - Punishment = Something that makes behavior **less likely** to repeat

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Table of consequences

	Positive	Negative
Reward	Providing something that makes behavior more likely to repeat Ex: Giving candy (or verbal praise) to people answering questions	Reinforcing a behavior by removing something unpleasant or unwanted Ex: "No homework if you behave the rest of the class period"
Punishment	Adding/providing something that makes behavior less likely to repeat Ex: Spanking, assigning a letter of apology	Discouraging a behavior by removing something desirable Ex: Taking away recess, cell phone privileges, etc.

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What is PBIS?

- PBIS = Positive Behavior Interventions and Supports
 - Common behavior management system implemented in schools
- Purpose: Promote prosocial behaviors, and reduce antisocial behaviors
- Methods:
 - Tier 1: School-wide expectations and reinforcers, heavy on positive reinforcement and lighter on punishment
 - Tier 2: Increased supervision, pre-correction, and opportunity for practice/reinforcement
 - Tier 3: Individualized behavior management assessments and interventions

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Is PBIS ND-affirming?

- Short answer:
 - Not really
- Analysis:
 - **Objectives:** Behavioral conformity
 - **Methods:** Exclusion from rewards is barely distinguishable from punishment
 - **Implementation:** "Expectations" likely to reflect neurotypical norms, unlikely to reflect neurodivergent characteristics
- Nuanced answer:
 - Probably not, but *maybe*, if implemented with careful consideration

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Applications for SLPs

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Next steps:
Putting it all together

1. Is this behavior appropriate for intervention? *Use a neurodiversity-affirming perspective.*

2. Use FBA to determine the function of behavior, as well as antecedents and consequences

3. Intervention: Functional replacement? Antecedent intervention? Varied consequences?



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Step 1: Select a target bx

• Meaningful and important; improves child’s QOL

• Easier to target high-frequency behaviors

• No need to address everything at once; 1-2 behaviors at a time, incremental progress is okay

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Step 1: Select a target bx

Neurodiversity-affirming targets	Controversial, problematic targets
• Emotional regulation • Reduced self-harm • Reduced aggression • Versatile, functional communication • Multimodal • Multipurpose • Advocating for self	• Sustained eye contact • Reduced stimming • Reduced echolalia • Oralism • Tolerating unpleasant stimuli

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Step 2: FBA

- Functions:
 - Request/obtain? Escape/avoid? Stimming?
- Antecedents:
 - Environmental stimuli (light, sound)
 - Social factors (social context, social demands)
 - Intrapersonal factors (hunger, fatigue, stress, demands of masking)
- Consequences:
 - Which consequences are currently employed?
 - Which consequences does this child respond to?
 - Do these consequences respect the child's humanity and autonomy?

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Step 3: Intervention

- Consider both **antecedent interventions** and **consequential interventions**!
- Antecedent intervention: Target the antecedent in order to prevent the challenging behavior
- Consequential intervention: Alter the consequences to reduce the frequency/duration/intensity of the challenging behavior

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Step 3a: Antecedent interventions

- Adult-implemented environmental accommodations
 - Control unwanted sensory input directly (e.g., dimmed lights) or indirectly (e.g., ear protection)
- Adult-implemented social/academic supports
 - Explicitly state the rules and expectations for group projects, "play-dates," unstructured recess time, etc.
- Direct instruction for self-advocacy
 - Ensure that the child has the skills and the opportunity to signal that they are overwhelmed, or can request their sensory needs

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Step 3a: Antecedent interventions

Example:
Visual Activity Schedules
https://doi.org/10.1044/2020_LSHSS-20-00073

VAS type	When to use	Example activities	Sample VAS
Across activity	Group activities change each session	- Warm up - Skill instruction - Practical activity and feedback - Group game play - Wrap up	
Within activity	Single task includes multiple components	- Board games - Card games - Art activity - Creating social media post - Completing multistep social interaction	
Identifying OTIs	Student has low engagement or participation in variable	- Board games - Card games - Art activity - Forms show the number of responses a student has to display to meet expectations - Materials choice - Partner choice - Activity order choice	
Incorporating choice	Students display challenging behavior frequently or try to regulate changes to activities	- Supporting multiple students at job site with different tasks - Everyone needs to practice social turn-taking, but other tasks will change to target different goals - Supporting students in inclusive elective technology courses	
Required tasks list	Typically, with older students who are completing varied tasks OR students have to complete some, not all tasks during therapy	- Supporting multiple students at job site with different tasks - Everyone needs to practice social turn-taking, but other tasks will change to target different goals - Supporting students in inclusive elective technology courses	

Note: VAS = visual activity schedule; OTIs = opportunities to respond.
*Images created using Boardmaker software.

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Step 3b: Consequential interventions

- Plan A:** Reinforce a preferred alternative behavior
 - Ex: If a child engages in aggressive or self-harm behavior when overwhelmed, praise/reward them when they use a stress ball or disengage to "cool down"
- Plan B:** Employ teaching or regulatory strategies embedded within consequence
 - Ex: Time-out is more than just withdrawing preferred activities, it may also be a quiet, safe space to re-regulate
- Avoid:** Corporal punishment, withdrawal of essentials
 - "Essentials" may include sensory needs, AAC, food/drink

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Step 3b: Consequential interventions

Example:
Behavior-specific praise
https://doi.org/10.1044/2020_LSHSS-20-00073

	BSP nonexamples	BSP examples
Behavioral	"Good job." "Awesome!" "Keep it up!" "Nicely done." "Good paper, you got an A!" "You did well." "I liked your project."	"Good job keeping your hands to yourself!" "I appreciate how much effort you're putting into this assignment." "Alexandra, thank you for lining up so quietly!" "You did a great job of providing examples to support this section." "I like the way you transitioned between paragraphs." "You've really improved your vocabulary. I can tell you're using more words in your writing."

Note: BSP = behavior-specific praise.

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Questions?

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